

Business Questions by Role – Central Superstore

Three executive dashboards (CEO, CFO, COO). Each role has its own scenario and its own questions, with no overlap between dashboards.

CEO – Strategic Performance Dashboard

Scenario / Story:

The company's executive team meets with the board every quarter to review how the Central region is performing. Leadership has seen sales continue to grow, but is concerned that this growth is not automatically turning into healthy profit. The CEO needs a single, high-level view that shows how sales, profit and margin have moved year over year, and whether that growth is being driven by winning more customers or by customers spending more on each order.

At the same time, the CEO must decide where to invest next. That means understanding which states and cities are generating profit and which are quietly losing money, which product categories carry the business, and which customer segments deserve strategic focus. Finally, the CEO wants to know how dependent the company is on its most valuable customers and how many customers come back to buy again, because customer loyalty will shape the expansion plan for the coming years.

Questions:

1. What are the total Sales, Profit and Profit Margin % for each year (2013–2016), and what is the year-over-year growth?
2. How many orders and unique customers did the company have each year, and how have the average order value and average items per order changed?
3. Which States and Cities are the highest and lowest in Sales and Profit?
4. What share of total Sales and total Profit does each Category (Furniture, Office Supplies, Technology) contribute?
5. How do the customer Segments (Consumer, Corporate, Home Office) compare in Sales, Profit, customer count and average order value?
6. Who are the top 10 customers by Profit, and what share of total profit do they represent?
7. What percentage of customers placed more than one order in the same year (repeat rate), and how has it changed over the years?

CFO – Profitability & Pricing Dashboard

Scenario / Story:

The finance team is preparing the annual profitability review for the executive committee. Although revenue is growing, a considerable share of sales lines are being sold at a loss, and the CFO needs to understand exactly where margin is being lost. The review starts with product economics: which sub-categories and individual products earn money, which destroy value, and how much profit each unit sold actually generates.

It then moves to pricing policy: how discount levels affect profit, at what point a discount turns a sale into a loss, in which states discounts are actually being applied, and how much of the total loss comes from heavily discounted lines. The CFO will use this dashboard to set discount limits, flag loss-making products for repricing or removal, and build a plan to reduce operating losses.

Questions:

1. What are the Sales, Profit and Profit Margin % for each Sub-Category, and which Sub-Categories are loss-making?
2. What is the Profit per unit sold for each Sub-Category?
3. What are the top 10 and bottom 10 products by Profit?
4. How does the Discount level affect Profit and Margin, and at what discount level do sales begin to lose money?
5. In which States are discounts applied, and how does the average discount rate in each State compare with its Profit?
6. What percentage of sales lines are loss-making (Profit < 0), what is the total loss amount, and where is it concentrated by Category and State?
7. What share of the total losses comes from lines sold with a discount of 30% or more?

COO – Operations & Fulfillment Dashboard

Scenario / Story:

The operations team is responsible for turning customer orders into on-time deliveries, and the COO needs a dashboard to monitor how well this process is performing. The COO wants to know how long each shipping mode really takes, how orders are distributed across the shipping modes, whether delivery times are improving over the years, and which states receive slower service.

The COO must also plan capacity. That means knowing when demand peaks during the year, which days of the week receive the most orders, and which categories and sub-categories drive the highest unit volumes that the warehouse has to stock and handle. These insights will be used to staff the warehouse, prepare inventory before the peak season, and decide whether premium shipping options are financially justified.

Questions:

1. What is the average Shipping Days (Ship Date – Order Date) for each Ship Mode?
2. How are orders, sales and profit distributed across the Ship Modes, and is the fastest mode financially justified?
3. Has the average Shipping Days improved or worsened from 2013 to 2016?
4. Which States receive the slowest and fastest deliveries (average Shipping Days)?
5. Which months show peak and low order volume and sales, and is the seasonality consistent every year?
6. Which days of the week receive the most orders?
7. Which Categories and Sub-Categories drive the highest unit volume (Quantity) that the warehouse must handle?